SONG OF GRATITUDE

*Singer **Sonu Nigam**'s latest releases mark a return to spiritual music and work that is close to his heart*



Q. There is a new Sonu Nigam rising... tell us more about him.
Thanks for not labelling this a 'comeback'! As a performer, I feel there is a cycle of life that has completed and I am on another cycle now. So there are tours, playback, albums, devotional music—but all on my terms. I have always enjoyed spiritual music; in fact, that is what I started singing with. 'Raam Siya Raam', for example, is the most recent one, and the verses of *Ramcharitmanas* that I've sung are very soothing.

Q. 'Bitter Betrayals' is your take on your life?
There is no better teacher than experience. While this single was initially my take on the iconic 'Achha Sila Diya', while working on it, we added a lot of things. Music and lyrics are there for expressing emotions when words fail. This is that too, and not aimed to stir any nest. But, what is that saying, if the shoe fits...(*laughs*).

Q. You are known to be opinionated. Has that harmed you?
If I have a right to my opinion, people have a right to theirs. Yes, I have been banned and sometimes even replaced. But I know that I am honest and my intentions are good. At the end of the day, it is about what I can share with my audience and how they receive me. In that aspect, I am blessed.

Q. Would you consider taking up acting?
I was a child artist in the 1980s. Thereafter, my family moved to Delhi and singing became my focus. I do appear in my music videos and I'm content with that. I am working with Bhushan [Kumar] on *Deewana 2*, the sequel to my 1999 music album *Deewana*. It is a treat to work with Bhushan because his ear for the next hit is spot on. I'm focusing on independent music for now, and loving it!

with Aarti Kapur Singh